

Bach's Ellipsis

"Ellipsis" or "elliptic progression" (in music theory) is a phenomenon similar to an interrupted cadence, when the expected functional resolution of a chord is skipped, and the first chord is connected to an unexpected chord, often dissonant and belonging to a different key. Rimsky-Korsakov and Tchaikovsky use the term "false progression". And Georgy Catoire introduced the term "ellipsis", which is firmly entrenched in the Russian-language literature on music theory.

In elliptical progression may enter different types of chords (triads, seventh chords, ninth chords...). In this collection shows examples of connections of dominant seventh chords.

Bach, BWV 846, Prelude C major, mm. 31-32

31 32

C: V⁷ F: V⁷

Bach, BWV 853, Prelude e $\flat$ minor, mm. 36-37

36 37

e $\flat$: V⁷ a $\flat$: V⁷

Bach, BWV 866, Prelude B $\flat$ major
m. 11

Ibid. mm. 15-16

Ibid. mm. 17-18

11 15 16 17 18

E $\flat$: V⁷ C: V⁷ F: V⁷ B $\flat$: V⁷ B $\flat$: V⁷(V⁹) E $\flat$: V⁷

Bach, BWV 540, Toccata in F major, mm. 423-425 (This progression occurs in Toccata three times in different keys.
See also mm. 203-204 and 317-318)

423 424 425

F: V⁷ G $\flat$: V² I⁶

Bach, BWV 542, Fantasia in g minor, mm. 43-44

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The image shows a musical score for measures 43 and 44 of J.S. Bach's Fantasia in g minor, BWV 542. The score is written for a grand staff (treble and bass clefs) in G minor (two flats) and common time (C). Measure 43 features a complex texture with a rapid sixteenth-note run in the right hand and a slower eighth-note accompaniment in the left hand. Measure 44 continues this texture, with a final cadence in the right hand. Chordal annotations are present: 'g: V⁷ (V⁹)(V¹¹)' in red text above the right hand in measure 43, and 'c: V⁷' in red text above the right hand in measure 44. A fermata is placed over the final note of the right hand in measure 44.